

The Paradox Museum Miami Aims to Trick the Eye

Paradox Museum Miami is a mixture of art, science, and fun.

The 1,000-square-meter museum is housed in Miami's Wynwood arts and entertainment area. It has more than 70 public displays known as exhibits. Executive director Samantha Impellizeri says these exhibits challenge the imagination.

She added that visitors can walk away from the experience with some really fun and interesting material for social media.

Paradox Museum has more than ten locations throughout North America, Europe and Asia. The Miami location, which opened in 2022, was the first in North America.

The term paradox is central to the museum and what visitors experience. A paradox is a situation or thing that has seemingly opposite or contradictory qualities.

"Each paradox is uniquely tied to its community," Impellizeri said. "So as you walk throughout the experience, you'll notice different themes and art installations that directly reflect not only Miami but the Wynwood community specifically."

Paradox Museum Miami guide Maria Wong walks through a mirror maze as she checks for areas that need cleaning, Tuesday, Jan. 28, 2025, in Miami. (AP Photo/Rebecca Blackwell)

Many of the displays at Paradox Museum suggest old carnival funhouses – buildings that had devices and rooms designed to surprise or amaze visitors.

Examples include the mirror maze, the spinning tunnel, and the upside-down room. The difference is that Paradox Museum explains the math and science behind each illusion.

"We're a top field trip destination for pre-K all the way up through college students," Impellizeri said. She added that the museum has a large number of educational activities that students can do before, during, and after the visit.

Like any museum, Paradox Museum plans to change its exhibits to keep visitors coming back.

"We're not going to be the same space in a year to three years from now," Impellizeri said.

Paradox Museum Miami introduced a new Zero Gravity Room last fall. Visitors can turn their smart phone cameras on and attach their phones to a spinning holder. Then they step into a large, slowly moving room designed to look like the inside of a space station. The resulting video makes it look as though they are walking up the wall and ceiling inside a room unaffected by gravity.

Paradox Museum is part of a movement towards so-called “immersive art experiences.” These kinds of art experiences often use technology to make the visitors feel like they are taking part in art rather than just looking at it.

“Immersive experiences around the world are increasing in popularity,” Impellizeri noted.

Members of the Miller family from Memphis, Tenn. pose inside an installation as they visit Paradox Museum Miami during a family trip celebrating the 50th birthday of Cassandra Miller, right, Tuesday, Jan. 28, 2025, in Miami. (AP Photo/Rebecca Blackwell)

Immersive art experiences have opened all over the world during the past 10 years or so. Examples include a company called Meow Wolf with several locations in the western United States, as well as a Van Gogh exhibit that has been traveling through North America, Europe and Asia since 2017. Superblue Miami, which opened in 2021, is another example.

Visitors generally take 60 to 90 minutes to make their way through Paradox Museum. Tickets normally cost \$26 for adults and teenagers and \$20 for children.

Seventeen-year-old Facundo Ildarraz and his family came to Miami from Argentina. Ildarraz said his mother found Paradox Museum online. He said it turned out to be a great chance to take fun photos with his family.

“I’ve been laughing since I went inside,” Ildarraz said. “It’s really amazing.”

Dennis Spiegel is head of a business advisory company called International Theme Park Services, Inc. Spiegel said immersive experiences are a natural progression of location-based entertainment. Location-based entertainment includes go-cart tracks, laser tag, paint ball, indoor skydiving, escape rooms and trampoline parks. These are activities that take visitors a few hours to go through.

“It’s a lot of little things that we’ve had in the industry for years, heightened by our new technology...to make the experience new and something people haven’t seen,” Spiegel said.

I’m John Russell.

David Fischer reported on this story for the Associated Press. John Russell adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Quiz - The Paradox Museum Miami Aims to Trick the Eye

Vocabulary

museum - n. พิพิธภัณฑ์, สถานที่จัดแสดงวัตถุ

entertainment - n. ความบันเทิง, การแสดงหรือกิจกรรมสาธารณะเพื่อความสนุกสนาน

challenge - v. ท้าทาย, กระตุ้นความสนใจหรือความคิด; เชิญชวนให้แข่งขัน

location - n. สถานที่ตั้ง, ที่ตั้งธุรกิจ

theme - n. แก่นเรื่อง, หัวข้อหลักของการนำเสนอทางศิลปะ

installation - n. งานศิลปะจัดวาง, งานศิลปะที่มักประกอบด้วยหลายส่วนและใช้วัสดุผสม

illusion - n. ภาพลวงตา, สิ่งที่หลอกหลวง

pre-K (pre-kindergarten) - n. โรงเรียนเตรียมอนุบาล, โรงเรียนสำหรับเด็กเล็กมาก

immersive - adj. ที่ดื่มด่ำ, ที่ให้ความรู้สึกเหมือนเข้าไปอยู่ในเหตุการณ์หรือสภาพแวดล้อมนั้นๆ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is the primary nature of Paradox Museum Miami?

- A) It is solely a gallery for classical art.
- B) It is a combination of art, science, and entertainment.
- C) It functions primarily as a scientific research facility.
- D) It is an exclusive venue for musical performances.

2. Where is Paradox Museum Miami located, and approximately how large is it?

- A) In downtown Miami, occupying 70 square meters.
- B) In Miami's Wynwood arts and entertainment area, covering 1,000 square meters.
- C) In a suburban district of Miami, with exactly 70 exhibits.
- D) Near the Miami Beach coastline, spanning 100 square meters.

3. According to Executive Director Samantha Impellizeri, what is an added benefit for visitors of the museum experience?

- A) They can acquire advanced scientific knowledge.
- B) They can obtain free artistic supplies.
- C) They can gather interesting material suitable for social media.
- D) They can participate in professional art workshops.

4. Which statement accurately describes the global presence of Paradox Museum?

- A) It has only one location in North America.
- B) The Miami location was the first one to open globally.
- C) It operates more than ten locations across North America, Europe, and Asia.
- D) All its locations are exclusively found within Europe.

5. What is the fundamental concept that underpins the Paradox Museum and its visitor experience?

- A) The study of ancient historical events.
- B) The principle of a paradox, involving seemingly contradictory qualities.
- C) The presentation of contemporary abstract art forms.
- D) The exploration of historical optical devices.

6. How does Paradox Museum Miami specifically connect its paradoxes to the local community?

- A) By showcasing only artists who are natives of Miami.
- B) By offering special themed events related to Miami's history.
- C) By incorporating themes and art installations that reflect Miami and the Wynwood community.
- D) By providing free entry to residents of the Wynwood area.

7. Many of the Paradox Museum's displays draw inspiration from what kind of traditional attraction?

- A) Classical sculpture gardens.
- B) Old carnival funhouses.
- C) Modern art galleries.
- D) Historical reenactment centers.

8. What is a key difference between the illusions at Paradox Museum and those found in old carnival funhouses?

- A) Paradox Museum's illusions are designed to be more frightening.
- B) Paradox Museum's illusions are much older and more traditional.
- C) Paradox Museum provides scientific and mathematical explanations for its illusions.
- D) Paradox Museum only features illusions, unlike funhouses which have other attractions.

9. Which age groups does Paradox Museum serve as a primary field trip destination?

- A) Only elementary school students.
- B) Primarily adult learners and art enthusiasts.
- C) Students ranging from pre-kindergarten through college.
- D) Exclusively high school students interested in STEM fields.

10. What is Paradox Museum's strategy to encourage visitors to return?

- A) To offer a significant discount on repeat visits.
- B) To continuously update and change its exhibits.
- C) To introduce new loyalty programs for frequent visitors.

D) To expand its food and beverage options.

11. What is a unique aspect of the recently introduced Zero Gravity Room at Paradox Museum Miami?

A) It uses advanced robotics to make visitors float.

B) It allows visitors to record videos that simulate walking on walls and ceilings in a space station-like environment.

C) It provides a realistic experience of zero gravity through a vacuum chamber.

D) It features a historical exhibit on space exploration.

12. Into what broader category of visitor experiences does Paradox Museum fit?

A) Traditional fine art museums.

B) Scientific discovery centers.

C) Immersive art experiences.

D) Historical preservation sites.

13. Which of the following is NOT mentioned as an example of an immersive art experience in the article?

A) Meow Wolf.

B) A traveling Van Gogh exhibit.

C) Superblue Miami.

D) The Museum of Modern Art.

14. What is the typical duration of a visit to Paradox Museum and the standard ticket prices?

A) 30-45 minutes, with tickets costing \$15 for all.

B) 60-90 minutes, with adult/teen tickets at \$26 and children's tickets at \$20.

C) 2-3 hours, with a flat rate of \$20 per person.

D) More than 90 minutes, with children's tickets costing \$26.

15. According to Facundo Ildarraz, what was a significant aspect of his enjoyment during his visit to Paradox Museum?

A) He found the scientific explanations to be highly informative.

B) He was deeply moved by the traditional art installations.

C) He appreciated the opportunity to take fun photos with his family.

D) He learned about the historical context of the Wynwood area.